Wherefore Do I Live?

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This Shabbat's portion begins with a prayer that is answered, and the answer hurts.

"And Isaac entreated the L-rd for his wife, because she was barren; and the L-rd let Himself be entreated of him, and Rebekah his wife conceived." Twenty years of waiting end in one verse. Then the next verse turns the joy upside down: "And the children struggled together within her; and she said: 'If it be so, wherefore do I live?'"

Rashi reads her words plainly and painfully. She said, "IF the pain of pregnancy be so great," then "WHY IS IT that I longed and prayed to become pregnant?" She has what she asked for, and it is not what she imagined.

Most of us know that moment. A job we prayed for, a move we planned for years, a family we built, a country we came home to. The thing arrives, and it comes with a struggle inside it that no one warned us about. And the question rises: if this is what it is, why did I want it?

She went to ask

What Rivka does next is the first lesson of the portion. She does not swallow the question, and she does not let it eat her. "And she went to inquire of the L-rd." Rashi says where she went: "at the school of Shem". She took her pain to a place of learning and asked someone who could see further than she could.

The answer did not take the struggle away. "Two nations are in thy womb, And two peoples shall be separated from thy bowels; And the one people shall be stronger than the other people; And the elder shall serve the younger." The pain stayed. What changed was that it now had a meaning. She was not carrying a mistake. She was carrying a future.

That is often all an honest answer can give. It does not promise the hard part will stop. It tells you what the hard part is for.

The man who only had today

Then the twins grow, and the portion sets their two answers to Rivka's question side by side.

"And the boys grew; and Esau was a cunning hunter, a man of the field; and Jacob was a quiet man, dwelling in tents." Rashi says which tents: "the tent of Shem and the tent of Eber". Yaakov sits in the same school his mother went to when she needed an answer.

Then comes the stew. Esau comes in from the field, faint with hunger, and asks for "some of this red, red pottage". Yaakov asks for the birthright in exchange, and Esau gives his reason for agreeing: "Behold, I am at the point to die; and what profit shall the birthright do to me?"

Esau has his own answer to "wherefore do I live?" He lives for now. A birthright is a promise about the future, a responsibility that passes down the generations. To a man who sees only this hour, it is worth less than a bowl of lentils. The Torah sums it up in five words: "So Esau despised his birthright."

He did not hate it. He simply could not see why it mattered. That is the danger in a hungry moment. It shrinks the world until all that is left is the stew.

A question in the haftarah

The haftarah for Toldot, from Malachi, opens with a people asking a question very close to Rivka's. "I have loved you, saith the L-rd. Yet ye say: 'Wherein hast Thou loved us?'"

These were Jews who had come home from exile to a small, poor land. They had prayed for return, and the return came with hardship and disappointment inside it. If this is love, they asked, where is it?

The prophet answers by sending them back to this week's portion: "Was not Esau Jacob's brother? Saith the L-rd; Yet I loved Jacob". Look at the two brothers, he says. Look at who kept the birthright, and what came of it. The proof of love is in the long story, not in any single hard day.

And then Malachi says where a confused people should go to ask. He describes the true priest: "The law of truth was in his mouth, And unrighteousness was not found in his lips; He walked with Me in peace and uprightness, And did turn many away from iniquity." And again: "For the priest's lips should keep knowledge, And they should seek the law at his mouth".

It is the same move Rivka made. When the question hurts, go to where the Torah is kept and ask.

Two ways to carry a question

So the portion leaves us with two ways to answer "wherefore do I live?"

One is Esau's: I am hungry now, I may die tomorrow, so what is the future to me? It sounds honest. It is really a surrender of the future to the moment.

The other is Rivka's and Yaakov's. The struggle is real, and I will not pretend it isn't. But I will take the question somewhere it can be answered, and I will let the answer stretch past today. The birthright is worth keeping even when I am faint, because it was never only mine.

For those of us who came to this land by choice, Rivka's question can come up in the middle of the struggle that came with the blessing. The portion does not scold her for asking. It only shows us where she went next.

This Shabbat, may we each find our tent of Shem and Eber, and keep our birthright even on the hungry days.

Shabbat shalom.

All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine

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Sources

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